

Word family: **once**

Base word: once

Part of speech: adverb (副詞) / conjunction-like time connector (時間連接用法) / noun-like fixed-expression element (固定表達中的成分)

Useful constructions/extensions: once a week, once only, once before, once again, once more, once upon a time, once in a while, at once, all at once, once and for all, once you..., once I..., once was, once-famous

Your passage contains:

> “These days I usually see her **once a week**...”

Here, **once** means:

one time during each week.

Meaning in this passage

In:

> **once a week**

once means:

one time in every period of one week.

So if you see your grandmother:

> once a week

you normally see her:

> one time each week.

Meaning: One time during each specified period.

繁體中文: **每個指定時間週期內一次；這裡指每星期一次**

中文翻譯:

> “These days I usually see her once a week.”

「現在我通常**每星期見她一次**。」

So:

****once a week = 每星期一次****

This is the exact passage meaning.

1. ****once = one time (一次) — 一次 ; 一回****

This is the basic numerical-frequency meaning.

****Meaning:**** One single time.

Practice 1

> “I called her ****once****.”

「我打過****一次****電話給她。」

Practice 2

> “I’ve only met him ****once****.”

「我只見過他****一次****。」

****once = 某個動作只發生一次****

2. ****once a week/day/month (每.....一次) — 每個週期一次****

This is the exact construction used in your passage.

Practice 3 — Original

> “I usually see her ****once a week****.”

「我通常****每星期見她一次****。」

Practice 4

> “We meet ****once a month****.”

「我們****每月見一次****。」

Practice 5

> “Take this medicine ****once a day****.”

「這種藥****每天服用一次****。」

****once a + time unit = 每一個指定時間單位內發生一次****

3. ****once every + period (每隔.....一次) — 每.....一次****

A close frequency construction.

Practice 6

> “We meet ****once every two weeks****.”

「我們****每兩星期見一次****。」

Practice 7

> “The system is checked ****once every six months****.”

「系統****每六個月檢查一次****。」

****once every X = 每隔 X 時間發生一次****

4. ****only once / just once (只一次) — 只有一次****

Practice 8

> “I made that mistake ****only once****.”

「那個錯誤我只犯過****一次****。」

Practice 9

> “Can you explain it ****just once**** more?”

「你可以再解釋****一次****嗎？」

****only/just once = 強調某件事只發生一次****

5. **once = at one time in the past (曾經) — 曾經；從前**

A major separate meaning.

Meaning: At some time in the past, especially when describing a former state that is no longer true.

Practice 10

> “I **once** lived near here.”

「我**曾經**住在這附近。」

Practice 11

> “She was **once** very shy.”

「她**以前曾經**很害羞。」

once = 在過去某個時候曾經如此，但現在未必仍然如此

6. **once + past state (以前曾經.....) — 曾經；一度**

Practice 12

> “He **once worked** for that company.”

「他**曾經在**那家公司工作。」

Practice 13

> “This building was **once** a school.”

「這座建築**以前曾經是**一所學校。」

once = 表示過去曾存在過的狀態 / 身份

7. **once-famous / once-popular (曾經著名 / 流行) — 曾經.....的**

A productive adjectival-style use.

Practice 14

> “The **once-famous** restaurant has now closed.”

「那間**曾經很有名的**餐廳現在已經結業。」

Practice 15

> “The **once-popular** product disappeared from the market.”

「那款**曾經很受歡迎的**產品已經退出市場。」

once + adjective = 曾經處於某種狀態、現在已不一定如此

8. **once before** (以前有一次) — 之前曾經一次

Practice 16

> “I’ve done this **once before**.”

「我**以前做過一次**。」

Practice 17

> “She had visited the city **once before**.”

「她**以前曾經到過這個城市一次**。」

once before = 在現在 / 所談時點之前曾經發生過一次

9. **once again** (再次) — 再次 ; 又一次

A major fixed expression.

Practice 18

> “I’d like to thank you **once again**.”

「我想**再次**感謝你。」

Practice 19

> “She tried **once again**.”

「她**再次**嘗試。」

once again = 又一次；再次發生同樣動作

10. **once more** (再一次) — 再次

Very close to **once again**.

Practice 20

> “Please say that **once more**.”

「請**再說一次**。」

Practice 21

> “He checked the figures **once more**.”

「他**再檢查了一次**那些數字。」

once more = 再做一次 / 再次發生

11. **once** = when / as soon as (當.....之後；一旦) — 一旦；當.....之後

A major conjunction-like use.

Meaning: From the moment that something happens; when a condition has been completed.

Practice 22

> “**Once** you understand the rule, it becomes easy.”

「**一旦**你明白這條規則，就會變得容易。」

Practice 23

> “**Once** the meeting ends, I'll call you.”

「**會議一結束 / 一旦會議結束**，我就打給你。」

****once + clause = 當某件事一發生 / 完成後，另一件事就會發生****

12. ****once you..., then... (一旦.....便.....) — 一旦；當.....之後****

Practice 24

> “****Once you start****, it gets easier.”

「****一旦開始了****，事情就會容易些。」

Practice 25

> “Once she arrives, we can begin.”

「****她一到達****，我們就可以開始。」

****once = 表示前面事件成立後，後面結果 / 行動隨即或自然發生****

13. ****once = after something has happened (在.....之後) — 等.....之後****

Practice 26

> “I relaxed ****once**** the presentation was over.”

「簡報結束****之後****，我就放鬆了。」

Practice 27

> “The problem became obvious once we checked the data.”

「我們檢查數據****之後****，問題就變得明顯。」

****once = 某事件完成後，另一情況隨之出現****

This can overlap with ****when****, but often carries a stronger “after the condition is achieved” idea.

14. ****once upon a time (從前) — 很久以前；從前****

A very common storytelling expression.

Practice 28

> “**Once upon a time**, there was a small village.”

「**從前**有一個小村莊。」

Practice 29

> “Once upon a time, people travelled much more slowly.”

「**很久以前**，人們旅行的速度慢得多。」

once upon a time = 用於故事開頭，表示很久以前某個不確定的時間

15. **once in a while (偶爾) — 偶爾；間中**

A major idiom.

Practice 30

> “I still feel nervous **once in a while**.”

「我仍然**偶爾**會感到緊張。」

Practice 31

> “We eat out once in a while.”

「我們**間中 / 偶爾**會外出吃飯。」

once in a while = 不經常，但偶爾會發生

16. **every once in a while (偶爾) — 偶爾；間中**

A common variant.

Practice 32

> “Every once in a while, she visits us.”

「她**偶爾**會來探望我們。」

Practice 33

> “I still make mistakes every once in a while.”

「我仍然**間中**會犯錯。」

every once in a while = occasionally ; 偶爾

17. **at once = immediately (立即) — 馬上 ; 立即**

A major fixed expression.

Practice 34

> “Come here **at once**.”

「**立即**過來。」

Practice 35

> “She answered **at once**.”

「她**馬上**回答。」

at once = 沒有延誤地立即做某事

This meaning is not simply “one time.”

18. **at once = at the same time (同時) — 同時**

A second established sense of the same expression.

Practice 36

> “I can’t do three things **at once**.”

「我不能**同時**做三件事。」

Practice 37

> “Everyone started talking ****at once****.”

「大家****同時****開始說話。」

****at once** = 多件事情在同一時間發生******

So ****at once**** itself is polysemous:

1. immediately;
2. simultaneously.

19. ****all at once** = suddenly (突然) — 突然；一下子******

Practice 38

> “****All at once****, the room went quiet.”

「****突然間****，房間安靜了下來。」

Practice 39

> “All at once, I remembered the answer.”

「我****突然一下子****想起答案。」

****all at once** = 某件事突然發生******

20. ****all at once** = all together / simultaneously (一下全部；同時) — 同時；一下子全都******

Practice 40

> “Don’t answer ****all at once****.”

「不要****大家同時****回答。」

Practice 41

> “The problems appeared all at once.”

「問題****一下子全都****出現了。」

****all at once** = 多個人 / 事物在同一時間一起發生******

Context distinguishes this from the “suddenly” use.

21. **once and for all (一次徹底解決) — 一勞永逸 ; 徹底地**

A major idiom.

Practice 42

> “Let’s solve the problem **once and for all**.”

「我們把問題**一次徹底解決 / 一勞永逸地解決**吧。」

Practice 43

> “She wanted to prove once and for all that she could do it.”

「她想**徹底證明**自己做得得到。」

once and for all = 最後、徹底地處理某件事，使它不需要再次處理

22. **once or twice (一次兩次 / 幾次) — 一兩次**

Practice 44

> “I’ve made that mistake **once or twice**.”

「我犯過那個錯**一兩次**。」

Practice 45

> “We met once or twice before.”

「我們以前見過**一兩次**。」

once or twice = 一次或兩次 ; 泛指極少次數

23. **once too often (多了一次 ; 終於出事) — 做得太多次 ; 一次過頭**

A useful idiom.

Practice 46

> “He ignored the warning **once too often**.”

「他忽視警告**太多次，終於出了問題**。」

Practice 47

> “She arrived late once too often.”

「她遲到**太多次，終於造成後果**。」

once too often = 某種不良行為重複到超過可接受界線，最後造成後果

24. **for once (就這一次 / 難得一次) — 這一次；難得一次**

A major conversational expression.

Practice 48

> “**For once**, everything went smoothly.”

「**難得這一次**，一切都很順利。」

Practice 49

> “For once, he arrived early.”

「他**難得一次**提早到了。」

for once = 與平常不同，這一次出現某個較不常見的情況

25. **just this once (就這一次) — 只限今次；就這一次**

Practice 50

> “I’ll help you **just this once**.”

「我**就這一次**幫你。」

Practice 51

> “Can we make an exception just this once?”

「我們可以**只限這一次**破例嗎？」

just this once = 只允許 / 發生這一次，不代表以後也一樣

26. **once in a lifetime (千載難逢 / 一生一次) — 一生難得一次**

A very common fixed expression.

Practice 52

> “It was a **once-in-a-lifetime opportunity**.”

「那是一個**一生難得一次的機會**。」

Practice 53

> “For her, the trip was a once-in-a-lifetime experience.”

「對她來說，那是一段**一生難得一次的經歷**。」

once in a lifetime = 極其罕見，可能一生只會遇到一次

27. **once in a blue moon (極少) — 極少；難得一次**

A common idiom.

Practice 54

> “He cooks **once in a blue moon**.”

「他**極少 / 難得一次**下廚。」

Practice 55

> “We see each other once in a blue moon.”

「我們**很少很少**見面。」

once in a blue moon = extremely rarely ; 非常罕見地

Informal idiom.

28. **once-over (快速查看 / 檢查) — 快速看一遍；簡單檢查**

A lexicalized noun expression.

Practice 56

> “Give the report a quick **once-over**.”

「把報告**快速看一遍 / 簡單檢查一下**。」

Practice 57

> “I gave the room a once-over before the guests arrived.”

「客人到之前，我把房間**快速檢查了一遍**。」

a once-over = 快速但整體地查看 / 檢查某物一次

Informal.

29. **the once + adjective/noun idea (昔日的 / 曾經的) — 昔日的；曾經的**

A somewhat formal/literary extension.

Practice 58

> “The once powerful company became much smaller.”

「那家**昔日強大的**公司規模縮小了很多。」

Practice 59

> “The once quiet neighbourhood became busy.”

「那個**昔日寧靜的**社區變得繁忙。」

once + adjective = 曾經具有某種特徵但現在已改變

Important distinction: **once** vs **one time**

For basic frequency:

once

= one time.

one time

can also mean one occasion, but **once** is normally more natural for counting frequency.

> “I called once.”

more natural than:

> “I called one time.”

The latter can sound contrastive or conversational in some varieties.

Important distinction: **once** vs **one**

one

is a number/determiner:

> one visit

once

is typically an adverb:

> visit once

So:

> one visit a week

and:

> once a week

can describe the same frequency but have different grammar.

Important distinction: **once a week vs every week**

once a week

specifies frequency:

> exactly/typically one occasion each week.

every week

only says:

> it happens each week.

It could happen more than once.

So:

> "I see her every week."

does not necessarily tell us how many times.

Important distinction: **once vs twice**

once

= one time.

twice

= two times.

Then normally:

> three times

> four times

not:

>  thrice

in ordinary modern English, though **thrice** exists and is literary/dated.

Important distinction: **once = once only vs **once** = formerly**

Compare:

> “I visited Paris once.”

= 去過巴黎一次。

versus:

> “I once lived in Paris.”

= 我曾經住在巴黎。

The first counts occasions.

The second locates a fact in the past.

This is one of the most important polysemy distinctions.

Important distinction: **once vs **used to****

Both can describe the past, but differently.

**once**

= at some past time.

> “I once lived there.”

**used to**

= repeated/habitual or continuing past state that no longer applies.

> “I used to live there.”

The second more strongly implies:

> I lived there for a period / it was my former state.

Important distinction: **once** vs **formerly**

once

= everyday and flexible.

formerly

= more formal, specifically “previously.”

> “The building was once a school.”

> “The building was formerly a school.”

Both natural, but **formerly** is more formal.

Important distinction: **once** vs **when**

In:

> “Once the meeting ends, I’ll leave.”

once means approximately:

> as soon as / after the condition is completed.

when

is more neutral:

> “When the meeting ends...”

Once often emphasizes that completion of the first event is the condition for the second.

Important distinction: **once** vs **as soon as**

They can overlap.

once

focuses on:

> after a condition/event has been achieved.

as soon as

strongly emphasizes:

> immediately after, with minimal delay.

> “Once I finish, I’ll call.”

= after I have finished.

> “As soon as I finish, I’ll call.”

= immediately after I finish.

Important distinction: **once vs if**

if

= condition may or may not happen.

once

often assumes the event will happen, and means:

> when it has happened.

Compare:

> “If she arrives...”

uncertain.

> “Once she arrives...”

speaker expects her arrival.

Important distinction: **once again vs again**

These are almost identical.

again

= another time.

once again

= slightly fuller/emphatic form of “again.”

> “Thank you again.”

> “Thank you once again.”

Both natural.

Important distinction: **once more vs one more**

once more

= perform the action again.

> “Say it once more.”

one more + noun

= add another item.

> “One more question.”

So:

once more = 再做一次

one more question = 再一個問題

Important distinction: **once in a while vs sometimes**

Both mean occasional frequency.

sometimes

= broad neutral occasional frequency.

once in a while

= not often; from time to time.

The idiom often emphasizes greater infrequency.

Important distinction: **at once = immediately vs at once = simultaneously**

This is a classic polysemy trap.

> “Come here at once.”

= **立即**過來。

But:

> “They all spoke at once.”

= 他們**同時**說話。

Same expression, genuinely different concepts.

Important distinction: **all at once vs at once**

at once

can mean:

* immediately;

* simultaneously.

all at once

often means:

* suddenly;

* everyone/everything simultaneously.

> “All at once, I understood.”

= 突然間我明白了。

Important distinction: **for once vs once**

once

simply counts one occasion.

for once

means:

> this occasion is unusual compared with the normal pattern.

> “He arrived early once.”

= 他有一次早到。

> “For once, he arrived early.”

= 他難得一次早到。

The second contains contrast with habit.

Important distinction: **once and for all vs once**

once

= one occasion.

once and for all

= finally and decisively, so repetition should no longer be necessary.

> “Solve it once.”

= 解決一次。

> “Solve it once and for all.”

= 徹底解決，不再留下問題。

Important distinction: ****once in a lifetime vs once in a while****

Almost opposite frequencies.

****once in a lifetime****

= extremely rare / possibly only one occasion in one's life.

****once in a while****

= occasionally.

Important distinction: ****once upon a time vs long ago****

Both refer to the past.

****once upon a time****

is a conventional storytelling opener, especially fairy tales.

****long ago****

is an ordinary time expression.

> "Once upon a time, there was a king."

storytelling.

> "The castle was built long ago."

ordinary factual statement.

Important distinction: ****once-over vs check****

****a once-over****

= quick general inspection.

****a check****

can be quick or detailed and often focuses on verifying correctness/status.

> “Give it a once-over.”

suggests:

> take a quick overall look.

Family-extension sweep

Once is not morphologically rich; its learning value comes from grammatical functions and fixed expressions rather than derivational family.

Useful modern constructions include:

- * **once — one time** = 一次
- * **once a week/day/month** = 每星期 / 日 / 月一次
- * **once every X** = 每隔 X 一次
- * **only/just once** = 只一次
- * **once — formerly** = 曾經 / 以前
- * **once-famous / once-popular** = 曾經著名 / 受歡迎的
- * **once before** = 以前曾有一次
- * **once again** = 再次
- * **once more** = 再一次
- * **once + clause** = 一旦 / 等.....之後
- * **once upon a time** = 從前
- * **once in a while** = 偶爾
- * **every once in a while** = 偶爾
- * **at once — immediately** = 立即
- * **at once — simultaneously** = 同時
- * **all at once — suddenly** = 突然
- * **all at once — simultaneously** = 一下子全都 / 同時
- * **once and for all** = 一勞永逸 / 徹底地
- * **once or twice** = 一兩次
- * **once too often** = 做得太多次而終於造成後果
- * **for once** = 難得一次
- * **just this once** = 只限這一次
- * **once in a lifetime** = 一生難得一次
- * **once in a blue moon** = 極少
- * **once-over** = 快速查看 / 檢查
- * **once + adjective** = 昔日 / 曾經.....

The main semantic/function branches are:

> **one occurrence**

> **frequency per period**

> **at some past time / formerly**

> **when a condition has happened**

> **repetition**

> **immediacy / simultaneity in fixed expressions**

> **rare frequency idioms**

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
-----	-----
once — one time	某個動作只發生一次
once a week/day/etc.	每個指定時間週期內發生一次
once every X	每隔指定時間發生一次
only/just once	強調某事只有一次、沒有更多次
once — formerly	在過去某個時候曾經如此，但現在未必仍然如此
once + adjective	曾經具有某個特徵，但現在情況已可能改變
once before	在目前 / 所談時間之前曾經發生過一次
once again	同一動作 / 情況再次發生
once more	再做一次 / 再次
once + clause	當某件事一發生 / 完成後，另一事情便會發生
once upon a time	故事開頭表示很久以前某個不確定時間
once in a while	不經常，但偶爾會發生
at once — immediately	沒有延誤地立即做某事
at once — simultaneously	多件事情在同一時間發生
all at once — suddenly	某件事情突然發生
all at once — simultaneously	多個人 / 事物一下子同時發生
once and for all	最後而徹底地處理某事，使其毋須再次處理
once or twice	一次或兩次；泛指極少次數
once too often	某種行為重複過多，終於造成不良後果
for once	與平常不同，這一次難得出現某種情況
just this once	只限這一次，不代表將來亦可如此
once in a lifetime	極其罕見，可能一生只會遇到一次
once in a blue moon	非常罕見地；極少
once-over	快速但整體地查看 / 檢查某物一次

For your original passage

> “These days I usually see her **once a week**, normally on Sunday afternoon...”

The exact meaning is:

once = one time

and the full frequency expression is:

once a week = 每星期一次

So the sentence means:

> during a normal week, you typically visit your grandmother one time.

This use should be distinguished especially from:

> **I once saw her there.**

Here:

once = 曾經 / 以前有一次

and:

> **Once I arrive, I'll call her.**

Here:

once = 一旦 / 等.....之後

The most important learner contrasts are:

> **once**

> = 一次

> **once a week**

> = 每星期一次

> **once every two weeks**

> = 每兩星期一次

> **I once lived there**

> = 我曾經住在那裡

> ****once before****

> = 以前有過一次

> ****once again****

> = 再次

> ****once more****

> = 再一次

> ****once you understand it****

> = 一旦你明白了

> ****once upon a time****

> = 從前

> ****once in a while****

> = 偶爾

> ****at once****

> = 立即；也可以是「同時」

> ****all at once****

> = 突然；一下子全都

> ****once and for all****

> = 一勞永逸 / 徹底解決

> ****for once****

> = 難得一次

> ****once in a lifetime****

> = 一生難得一次

So ****once**** is much richer than simply:

> ****once = 一次****

and in your original sentence it specifically means:

*****“one time during each week.”*****